

Fauvism

In 1905, Matisse, Derain, Braque, Kees van Dongen (1877–1968), Raoul Dufy (1877–1953) and Maurice de Vlaminck (1876–1958) held a group exhibition in Paris, at the fairly new Salon d'Automne. Their deliberately crude and vividly colourful canvases, with free brushwork and broken lines, outraged critics, and the moniker 'Les Fauves' (Wild Beasts) was given to them in contempt. Also ridiculed and derided by the public, their absence of tone, non-naturalistic depictions and colours seemed absurd and illogical.

Fauvism was a development of Post-Impressionism: the artists involved were all inspired by Cézanne's exploration of solidity, Van Gogh's angled and expressive brushstrokes, and his and Seurat's use of pure, unmixed colours and simultaneous contrast. Abandoning theories and lifelike representations, the artists intentionally focused on colours and marks, embracing the flatness of their canvases and vivacity of their paint. The images still loosely represented life, but distorted it to explore the effects of colours and marks and create a new, free visual language.



Dufay, *Madame Matisse in Kimono*, 1905